

Module 3: Impacts of Animal Agriculture: Part 2

Labor and rights

Week 2 | Online-Synchronous | Tuesday[1]

This session examines animal agriculture as a labor system and explores how prevailing production models shape working conditions, occupational risks, and rights across livestock production and meat processing. Fellows will examine how cost pressures, consolidation, and speed-driven production contribute to unsafe, precarious, and often invisible labor conditions.

The session situates labor justice as a core pillar of Just Food Systems, emphasizing that harm within animal agriculture is not limited to animals or the environment, but is also borne by workers whose bodies, health, and dignity are routinely placed at risk.

Resources[2]

For this session, you will engage with materials that examine labor conditions in animal agriculture from global and Philippine perspectives.

A. Labor Conditions and Worker Rights (Global)

1. [Human Rights Watch – When We're Dead and Buried, Our Bones Will Keep Hurting: Workers' Rights Under Threat in Meat and Poultry Plants](#)

This report documents unsafe working conditions, injuries, and barriers to organizing in meat and poultry processing. Pay attention to how speed, productivity demands, and corporate power shape labor harm.

2. [Bureau of Labor Statistics – Injuries, Illnesses, and Fatalities in Animal Slaughtering and Processing](#)

This data-driven resource shows that meatpacking and slaughterhouse work consistently ranks among the most dangerous occupations. Pay attention to injury rates and compare them to other industrial sectors.

3. [Oxfam – Lives on the Line: The Human Cost of Cheap Chicken](#)

This report examines how pressure for low-cost animal products drives labor exploitation in poultry supply chains. Consider how “cheap food” narratives externalize costs onto workers.

B. Labor and Agriculture in the Philippine Context

1. [Briones, R. M. \(Philippine Institute for Development Studies\). Agriculture, Rural Employment, and Inclusive Growth. Philippine Institute for Development Studies.](#)

This paper analyzes employment conditions in Philippine agriculture and rural labor markets, characterizing them as predominantly informal, low-skilled, low-productivity, and closely linked to persistent poverty. While not focused exclusively on animal agriculture, the analysis provides essential structural context for understanding labor conditions across livestock production and agribusiness value chains.

Exercise: Labor, Structure, and Justice

Please complete this exercise before the live session.

1. Identify **one labor condition** common in animal agriculture or agribusiness (e.g., informality, low wages, unsafe work, lack of social protection).
2. Using one global resource and the Briones paper, explain how this condition is shaped by structural features of agricultural production rather than individual employer behavior.
3. Reflect on how productivity, food affordability, and labor costs are connected, and who bears the risks within this system.
4. Briefly consider how improving labor conditions might interact with animal welfare and environmental goals—where do you see alignment, and where do you see tension?

Responses may be in short paragraphs or bullet points.